SMALL BUSINESS BASICS · CANADA

Online Booking Made Simple

Choose and set up an appointment system that fits your business

A plain-language guide for Canadian small-business owners

First edition · November 2026

Online Booking Made Simple — Choose and set up an appointment system that fits your business

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Important. This guide is general information for Canadian small-business owners. It is not legal, tax, accounting, or financial advice, and it does not create a professional relationship of any kind. Rules, rates, forms, and software features change. Before you act, check the official source named in the guide and, where the stakes are real, talk to a qualified professional who knows your situation.

Nothing in this guide is legal, tax or privacy advice. Consumer protection, privacy and anti-spam rules differ by province and can change, so have your policies reviewed and check the official sources named in the guide.

No result is promised. How useful any idea in this guide turns out to be depends on your business, your customers, your market, and how you apply it.

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Before you start

What this guide covers

This is a plain-language guide to choosing and setting up an online booking system: a tool that lets a customer pick a time for an appointment, a class or a service call without phoning you first. It walks you through deciding whether you need one, working out what it has to do, asking vendors the right questions, setting it up, writing your policies and messages, launching it, and reviewing it later.

It is written for Canadian small-business owners who take appointments or schedule visits: stylists, massage therapists, groomers, tutors, photographers, cleaners, trainers, bookkeepers, and trades who book estimates and service calls. Restaurants and hotels usually need specialized reservation systems, which this guide does not cover.

What it is not

This guide is general information, not legal, tax, accounting or privacy advice. Booking systems touch on privacy law, anti-spam rules, consumer protection and sales tax. Those rules differ by province and they change. Where you are close to one of those decisions, the guide says so and points you to the official source or the right professional.

Software changes too. Any product named here is an example only, at the time of writing. None is a recommendation, and none is ranked above another. Check the current version of any tool before you decide.

How to use the worksheets

Every main chapter ends with key points. The worksheets and templates are collected in the *Templates and worksheets* chapter so you can print them in one go. Keep them, along with your vendor notes and policy drafts, in one folder (paper or digital). When you review your system later, or switch tools, you will be glad you did.

Do you need a booking system?

An online booking system is not a must-have for every business. For some owners it removes a lot of back-and-forth messages. For others it adds a monthly bill and a new set of settings to manage, with little benefit. This chapter helps you decide which group you are in.

Signs it might help

Look at how bookings happen in your business today. A booking system may be worth a closer look if several of these sound familiar:

- You spend real time on phone tag and messages that go “Does Tuesday work?” “No, how about Thursday?”
- You miss calls while you are with a client, on a ladder or driving.
- People ask to book outside your working hours, and you answer the next morning.
- Your schedule lives in more than one place (a paper book, your phone, a whiteboard) and they do not always match.
- You or your staff have double-booked someone.
- You want deposits for some services but have no easy way to collect them.
- You send reminders by hand, or you mean to and forget.
- You run classes and track spots on a list.

When phone, text or email is fine

You may be better off without a booking system, at least for now, if your work is mostly quoted jobs (a renovation or a custom order needs a conversation before anyone can pick a date), if you only take a few bookings a week, if every job is a different length until you see it, or if your services usually start with a conversation about fit, as counselling or financial work often does.

There is a middle ground. Many tools let customers *request* a time, which you then accept or decline. That keeps you in control while still cutting down on messages.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a mobile dog-grooming van out of Kentville. You book about thirty appointments a week, mostly by text, and you often answer messages at night. Every groom is one of three lengths depending on the size of the dog. A booking system with three services, a travel buffer and automatic reminders could save you a lot of evening texting. A cabinet maker in the same town who books two or three site visits a month is probably fine with “Call or email to book a site visit” on the website.

The real costs to weigh

The subscription is only part of the cost. Plan for setup time (an afternoon or two to enter services, hours, policies and messages, and to test), learning time for you and your staff, payment processing fees if you take money online, and ongoing care. Someone has to keep hours, holidays and prices up to date, because a booking page that offers times you are not available is worse than no booking page. Write these costs down next to the time you spend on scheduling now. That gives you a fair comparison.

It also helps to think about what you would do with the time. If scheduling messages eat into your evenings, getting those evenings back may matter more to you than the dollar figure. If you would simply fill the time with more admin, the case is weaker. There is no right answer, only the one that fits your business and the way you like to work.

A quick decision test

Answer three questions honestly. Do I book many appointments that are similar in length? Do I lose real time, or real bookings, to back-and-forth messages? Am I willing to spend an afternoon setting it up and a few minutes a week keeping it current? If you answered yes to all three, keep reading. If not, a clear “how to book” line on your website and a prompt reply to messages may be all you need for now. You can revisit the question when your business changes.

KEY POINTS

- A booking system helps most when you book many similar appointments and spend real time on messages.
- Quoted, irregular or low-volume work may be better served by phone, email or a request form.
- “Request a time” booking is a middle ground that keeps you in control.
- Count setup, learning, fees and upkeep, not just the monthly price.

Types of tools and what you need

Booking tools come in a few broad families. Knowing which family fits, and what your must-haves are, narrows your search. Product names below are examples only, at the time of writing. They are not recommendations or rankings, and features and prices change, so check each vendor's current version.

The main families

Simple scheduling links give you a booking page that shows open times based on your calendar. They suit consultants, tutors, coaches and anyone who mainly needs "pick a time to meet." Examples include Calendly, Acuity Scheduling, Microsoft Bookings and the appointment schedule feature in Google Calendar. Watch for limits on staff, shared rooms, intake forms or class sizes.

Industry-specific tools are built for one type of business. Salon tools often handle stylists and processing time, clinic tools often include intake forms and notes, field service tools often add quotes and invoicing, and studio tools handle classes and passes. Examples include Fresha and Vagaro (salons and wellness), Jane (clinics), Mindbody (fitness and wellness studios), and Jobber and Housecall Pro (home services and trades). They fit well when your needs match, but your client history lives inside the tool, which can make leaving harder.

Booking built into a point of sale (POS) or website builder keeps payments, customer records and your website in one place. Examples include Square Appointments, Wix Bookings and Squarespace's scheduling feature. Check whether the booking features are as complete as a dedicated tool, and what happens to your booking data if you later change platforms.

If your business mostly...	Look first at...
Books one-on-one meetings or calls	Simple scheduling links
Has several staff with different services	Industry tools or POS booking
Needs health intake forms and notes	Clinic tools
Sends crews to homes and invoices after	Field service tools
Runs classes with limited spots	Studio or class tools

Your services, staff and resources

Next, turn your business into a list of requirements, using the needs worksheet in the *Templates and worksheets* chapter. List every service a customer could book: a clear name, how long it really takes, any buffer time before or after (cleaning a room, writing notes, driving), the price, and who

or what it needs (staff, a room, equipment). Keep the list short, and group small variations as add-ons. Then note how many people take bookings, and where you work. If you go to customers, note your service area and travel time.

Payments, forms and other features

Decide what to collect at booking: nothing, a card on file, a deposit, or full payment. Then list your **intake questions**, what you truly need to know before the appointment. A groomer may need the dog's size. A cleaner may need the number of rooms. Every extra question is more personal information to protect, so if you would not use the answer, do not ask.

Mark each as *must have*, *nice to have* or *not needed*: reminders, two-way calendar sync, waitlists, recurring bookings, reports, and accounting connections. Two things are easy to forget. **Language:** if you serve customers who prefer French, can the booking page and messages be shown in French? **Accessibility:** can the page be used with a keyboard and a screen reader, is the text clear, and can a customer easily find another way to book? Some provinces have accessibility laws, so check your province's requirements.

Circle your must-haves. A tool that misses one is off the list. Nice-to-haves only break ties.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a two-person massage therapy clinic in Moncton. Your must-haves are two therapists with separate hours, one shared treatment room, health intake forms, reminders, and a card on file. French booking pages are a nice-to-have. A scheduling link that cannot handle the shared room is out, even if it is cheaper.

> **KEY POINTS**
>
> - Pick the family of tool first, then compare two or three tools inside it.
> - List every service with its real duration, buffer, price and who can do it.
> - Ask only intake questions you will use.
> - Check language and accessibility, not just the features you want.
> - Must-haves build the shortlist; nice-to-haves break ties.

Choose a vendor and test it

With your must-haves in hand, build a shortlist of two or three tools. This chapter covers comparing them, the privacy questions to ask, and how to trial a tool before you commit.

Build a shortlist

Use the vendor comparison table in the *Templates and worksheets* chapter. Check every must-have against the vendor's own website and help pages, not an advertisement, and note which plan you would need for each feature. Also note the things that are easy to miss: payment processing fees and whether you must use the vendor's processor, whether text reminders cost extra, contract terms and what happens if you cancel, how to reach a person for support, and whether you can export your customer list and booking history in a common format such as a spreadsheet file.

Privacy questions to ask vendors

When you use a booking tool, your customers' names, contact details, appointment history and intake answers are stored on the vendor's systems. In Canada, private-sector privacy law applies to personal information you collect in commercial activity: PIPEDA federally, while Alberta, British Columbia and Quebec have their own laws. In plain terms, you are expected to collect only what you need, protect it, and tell people what you do with it.

One point matters most here: **when you use cloud software, you remain responsible for the information.** Choosing a vendor does not hand that responsibility to them. So ask before you sign up. The full list of questions is in the *Templates and worksheets* chapter. The main ones are where the data is stored, who at the vendor can see it, how it is protected, whether you can export all of it at any time, what happens to it when you close your account, and how they will tell you about a breach.

Also read the vendor's privacy policy and terms of service, and note anything about using your customers' information for the vendor's own purposes, such as marketing. You may not understand every answer. That is fine. A vendor that answers clearly and in writing is easier to trust than one that does not answer at all. Keep the answers in your folder.

> **NOTE**
>
> Health information can come with stricter rules, and some provinces have separate health privacy laws. If you run a clinic or collect health details, check your province's rules and your regulatory college's guidance, and consider a privacy lawyer. The Office of the Privacy Commissioner of Canada (priv.gc.ca) has guidance for businesses.

Trial before you commit

Many tools offer a free trial or a free plan. Use it as a real test. Enter three or four real services and your real hours, including a break and a day off. Then:

1. Book as a customer on your phone and on a computer. Was anything confusing?
2. Book a service that needs a deposit. Check what the customer sees and what you receive.
3. Cancel and reschedule as a customer. Does your policy show? Does the slot reopen?
4. Read the confirmation and reminder messages. Can you change the wording?
5. Add a personal appointment to your own calendar. Does that time disappear from the booking page?
6. Export your test data. Can you open the file?
7. Ask support a simple question. How fast and clear was the answer?

Ask a friend or a trusted regular to make a test booking too. You know how the tool is supposed to work. They do not, which makes them a better tester. And put a reminder in your calendar a few days before the trial ends, so you decide calmly instead of being charged for a plan you have not chosen.

KEY POINTS

- Compare two or three tools against your must-haves, using each vendor’s own information.
- You remain responsible for customer information stored in cloud software. Ask vendors privacy questions and keep their answers.
- Health information needs extra care. Check your province’s rules.
- Use the trial as a real test: book, pay, cancel, sync, export and contact support.

Set it up step by step

Once you have chosen a tool, set it up in a sensible order. Most booking tools follow a similar pattern, though their menus and labels differ, so check your tool's help pages for where each setting lives.

Your business, services and hours

Step 1: Business details

Enter your business name, contact details, service area and time zone. Get the time zone right, especially if you serve customers in more than one province. If you work from home or go to customers, check what the booking page shows. You may not want your home address public. Many tools let you show a service area or share the address only after booking.

Step 2: Services menu

Enter the services from your needs worksheet with a clear name and a one-line description of what is included. Set the duration and the buffer separately if your tool allows it, so the customer sees "60 minutes" while your calendar holds 75. Make sure the price shown matches what you charge. Assign the staff, room or equipment each service needs, and put the most-booked services first.

Step 3: Availability rules

This is where you tell the tool when you can be booked. Look for these settings:

- **Working hours** for each day, including breaks.
- **Lead time** (sometimes called minimum notice): how soon before an appointment someone can book. If you need time to prepare or travel, you may not want a booking for twenty minutes from now.
- **Booking window:** how far ahead people can book. Too long can fill dates before you know your plans. Too short can frustrate regular clients.
- **Start-time intervals:** every 15 minutes, every half hour, on the hour.
- **Daily limits**, such as no more than four service calls a day.
- **Holidays and time off.** Add statutory holidays, vacations and closures now, not the week before.

EXAMPLE

Say you run an appliance repair business in Sydney, Nova Scotia, with one technician. Service calls are set at 90 minutes plus a 30-minute travel buffer. Lead time is the next business day, the booking window is three weeks, and there is a limit of four calls a day. Customers choose a morning or afternoon arrival window rather than an exact start time, because travel can vary.

Your staff, questions and testing

Step 4: Staff and access

Set up each staff member with their own login, hours and services, and connect their calendar so personal commitments block booking times. Give each person only the access they need. Staff may need their own schedule and the details for their appointments, but not the whole customer list or financial reports. When someone leaves, remove their access the same day.

Step 5: Intake questions

Add only the questions you need to do the job safely and well, and mark them optional unless you truly need the answer. Avoid collecting sensitive details such as health, financial or identity information unless the tool is designed for it and you have a clear reason. Never ask for a Social Insurance Number in a booking form. Add one line saying why you ask, for example: “We ask about pets so we can bring the right equipment. We only use your answers to prepare for your visit.”

Step 6: Policies, messages, payments and testing

Add your policies, messages and payment settings (next chapter). Make sure your policy appears *before* the customer confirms the booking, not only in the confirmation email. Then make at least three test bookings: a simple one, one with a deposit, and one that you cancel. Check every message, calendar entry and payment, then delete or refund the tests.

KEY POINTS

- Set up in order: details, services, availability, staff, intake questions, policies and messages, then testing.
- Separate service duration from buffer time.
- Use lead time, booking window and daily limits to protect your schedule.
- Give staff only the access they need, and remove it when they leave.

Policies, messages and payments

A booking system makes it easy to book, and just as easy to cancel or not show up. Clear policies, good messages and careful payment settings help set fair expectations on both sides.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Consumer protection laws are provincial, and rules on deposits, cancellation fees and consumer contracts vary. This is general information, not legal advice. Before you charge fees or keep deposits, have your wording reviewed by a lawyer or check with your province's consumer protection office.

Deposits, cancellations and no-shows

The most important thing is *when and how* the customer sees your policy. State deposit and cancellation terms clearly **before** the customer books and get their agreement: show the policy next to the confirm button, use a tick box if your tool has one, repeat it in the confirmation message, and post the same wording on your website. A fee the customer first hears about after a missed appointment is much harder to justify, and may not be allowed.

Then decide the details:

- **Deposits:** which services need one, how much (a reasonable fixed dollar amount), and when it is refunded.
- **Notice:** how much notice you need to cancel or reschedule. Choose a period you can explain, such as 24 or 48 hours, that fits how long it takes you to fill a slot.
- **Late cancellations and no-shows:** whether the customer loses the deposit, pays a fee, or gets a warning the first time. If you will waive it for emergencies or bad weather, say so, so nobody thinks you play favourites.
- **Late arrivals:** how long you will wait, and whether you shorten or reschedule the appointment.
- **When you cancel:** what the customer gets if *you* cancel or run late. A policy that applies to both sides is easier to explain and feels fairer.

Allow online rescheduling within your notice period, so customers have an easy alternative to not showing up. A sample policy is in the *Templates and worksheets* chapter.

Applying your policy fairly

A policy only helps if you apply it the same way each time. Write down, for yourself and your staff, who can waive a fee and when. Keep a note on the booking whenever you charge or waive a fee, and why. If a customer disputes a charge, you can then show what they agreed to, when, and what happened.

If you keep a card on file, tell the customer plainly at booking what it may be charged for, and charge only what your policy says. When you do charge a fee, send a short, polite message explaining it (there is a template in the *Templates and worksheets* chapter). If a slot opens up at short notice, a waitlist feature, where your tool has one, can offer it to someone else. Finally, review your policy at your three-month check-in. If it feels too strict or too loose for your business, adjust it, have the new wording reviewed, and update it everywhere it appears.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a one-chair barbershop in Antigonish. No deposit for regular cuts. First-time colour services need a $25.00 deposit that goes toward the bill, refunded in full with at least 24 hours' notice. Late cancellations and no-shows forfeit it. If the barber cancels, the customer gets a refund or a new booking, their choice. The policy shows before booking, in the confirmation and on the website, and a lawyer read the wording first.

Confirmations, reminders and anti-spam rules

Most tools send a confirmation, one or more reminders, and notices when a booking changes. Rewrite the default messages in your own words. Include everything the customer needs to show up on time and prepared: date, time, service, address or arrival window, what to bring, price, your policy and how to change the booking. Templates are in the *Templates and worksheets* chapter.

Canada's Anti-Spam Legislation (CASL) applies to commercial electronic messages, such as marketing emails and texts. Messages about a service a customer has already booked, like confirmations and reminders, are generally treated differently from marketing. Promotional messages need consent. In practice, keep reminders free of offers and promotions. If you want to send newsletters or specials, add a separate, unticked box on your booking form asking permission, keep a record of who agreed and when, and make unsubscribing easy. If you are unsure whether a message counts as marketing, ask a lawyer.

Payments, taxes and records

If your tool takes payments, check the processing fees (including on refunds), how long payouts take, who can issue refunds, and whether payments flow into your accounting software.

If you are registered for GST/HST, how tax applies to deposits, cancellation fees and no-show fees can depend on the details, such as whether a deposit is applied to a service you later provide or kept as a fee. **Ask your accountant how GST/HST applies to deposits and fees in your business** before you turn them on, and check current rates on CRA's GST/HST pages at canada.ca/revenue-agency.

Your booking tool now holds part of your business records. CRA generally requires you to keep books and records for six years from the end of the last tax year they relate to, and electronic records are acceptable if they are readable and available on request. Confirm the current rules at

canada.ca/revenue-agency, and export your payment records to your books regularly rather than relying on the booking tool alone.

KEY POINTS

- Show deposit and cancellation terms before booking, get agreement, and repeat them in the confirmation and on your website.
- Have your policy wording reviewed. Consumer rules vary by province.
- Keep reminders transactional, and get separate consent for marketing messages.
- Ask your accountant how GST/HST applies to deposits and fees, and export payment records regularly.

Launch, review and switch

A booking system only helps if people can find it. This chapter covers putting your link everywhere, telling customers, handling the people who still call, reviewing the setup, and leaving cleanly if you ever switch.

Put the booking link everywhere

Add a clear “Book now” button near the top of your website and on each service page. Depending on your business category, Google Business Profile may let you add a booking or appointment link; check Google Business Profile Help at support.google.com/business for what is available to you. Add the link to your social media profiles, your email signature, your voicemail greeting, business cards, receipts and any sign at your counter, and send it whenever someone asks to book.

Many website builders let you create a short address such as yourbusiness.ca/book that points to your booking page. It is easier to type, and if you ever switch tools, you only change the link in one place.

Tell customers and keep the phone line open

Pick a launch date and tell existing customers a week or two ahead, in person, with a sign at the counter, or with a short email or text. Keep that announcement about the booking change itself. If you add an offer, it becomes marketing, and it should only go to people who agreed to receive marketing. If you move existing future appointments into the new system, check each one, and tell those customers if they will start getting automatic reminders.

Not every customer will want to book online, and some cannot use an online page easily. Online booking should be an extra door, not the only one. Keep your phone number or email visible on the booking page, enter phone bookings in the same system so there is one calendar, and give staff a short script so everyone explains policies the same way. “You can also book online next time” is enough. Do not insist.

Review after a few months

Put a review in your calendar about three months after launch, then once or twice a year. Use the review worksheet and ask: Are durations and buffers right? Which services does nobody book? What questions do customers keep asking (the answers belong on the booking page)? How are cancellations and no-shows going by your own count? Are reminders going out on time? Which intake questions can go? Who still has access and should not? What does the tool really cost now, with fees and text charges? Is it still worth it?

EXAMPLE

Say you run a tutoring business in Charlottetown. At your three-month review, you see parents booking the 30-minute session for homework that really needs an hour. You rename the services “Quick check-in (30 min)” and “Full homework session (60 min),” add a one-line description to each, and remove a login for a tutor who left in the spring.

Switching systems and exporting data

Consider switching if your must-haves have changed and the tool cannot keep up, if costs have outgrown the benefit, if support is not there when you need it, or if you are uneasy about how the vendor handles your customers’ information. When you switch:

1. **Export everything first:** customers, upcoming and past bookings, intake answers, payment and refund records, and marketing consent records. Check that each file opens and is complete, and store the exports securely.
2. **Overlap briefly.** Set up and test the new tool while the old one runs, then pick a cut-over date.
3. **Move future appointments and consent records carefully.** Do not assume everyone on your list agreed to marketing.
4. **Update every link** and tell customers.
5. **Close the old account properly.** Ask the vendor to confirm in writing when your data will be deleted, and keep what you need for tax records.

KEY POINTS

- Put your booking link on your website, Google Business Profile, social profiles, email signature, voicemail and printed material.
- Keep phone and email open, and enter every booking in one system.
- Review about three months after launch, then once or twice a year.
- Before switching, export and check all your data, including consent and payment records.

Templates and worksheets

Copy, print or adapt these. Anything in [square brackets] is a placeholder for your own details.

Needs worksheet

WORKSHEET

Services (name, duration, buffer, price, who can do it):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

Staff who take bookings, and their hours: _____

Location, or service area and travel time: _____

Rooms or equipment that limit bookings: _____

At booking I collect (nothing, card on file, deposit, full payment): _____

Intake questions I truly need: _____

Reminders (email, text, how far ahead): _____

Calendar to sync with: _____

French and accessibility needs: _____

Must-haves: _____

Nice-to-haves: _____

Monthly budget for tool and fees: $_____

Hours I spend on scheduling now, per week: _____

Vendor comparison table

Fill in one column per tool from the vendor's own website, and note the date you checked.

Question	Tool A	Tool B	Tool C
Meets all my must-haves?			
Plan needed and monthly cost			
Payment processing fees			
Text reminders included or extra			
Syncs with my calendar			
French booking page			
Works well on a phone			
Data export format			
Contract and cancellation terms			
How to reach support			
Privacy answers in writing			
Trial result (good, okay, poor)			
Date checked			

Vendor privacy questions

TEMPLATE

Subject: Privacy questions before we sign up

Hi, we are considering [Tool name] for online booking at [Business name]. Could you answer these in writing?

1. Where is our customers' information stored, and is it ever transferred to or accessed from other countries?
2. Which of your staff or subcontractors can access it, and why?
3. How is it protected when stored and when sent?
4. Do you use our customers' information for anything other than providing the service to us?
5. Can we export all our data at any time, including booking history, intake answers and consent records? In what format?
6. When we close our account, when is our data deleted? Will you confirm in writing?
7. How and how quickly will you tell us about a privacy breach that affects our customers?
8. If we collect health information in intake forms, is your tool designed for that?
9. Where can we read your current privacy policy and terms of service?

Thank you, [Your name], [Business name], [Phone or email]

Cancellation and deposit policy

WATCH OUT

Sample wording only, not legal advice. Consumer protection rules vary by province. Have your final policy reviewed by a lawyer or check with your province's consumer protection office before you use it.

TEMPLATE

Booking, cancellation and deposit policy

Deposits. [Service names] require a deposit of $[amount] at booking. Your deposit is applied to the cost of your appointment.

Cancelling or rescheduling. You can cancel or reschedule online or at [phone or email] up to [24/48] hours before your appointment. Your deposit will be refunded in full or moved to your new booking, whichever you prefer.

Late cancellations and no-shows. With less than [24/48] hours' notice, or if you do not attend, [your deposit is not refunded / a fee of $[amount] applies]. We understand emergencies happen and may waive this at our discretion.

Late arrivals. If you arrive more than [number] minutes late, we may need to shorten or reschedule your appointment.

If we cancel. We will contact you as soon as possible and refund your deposit or move it to a new booking, whichever you prefer.

By booking, you agree to this policy. Questions? Contact us at [phone or email].

Confirmation message

TEMPLATE

Subject: Your appointment with [Business name] is confirmed

Hi [First name], you are booked for [Service] with [Staff name] on [Day, Date] at [Time], at [Address or arrival window]. [What to bring or how to prepare.] Price: [Price] ([Deposit paid, if any]).

Need to change it? Reschedule or cancel at [link] at least [24/48] hours ahead. Our policy: [link].

[Your name], [Business name], [Phone]

Reminder message (text or email)

TEMPLATE

Hi [First name], a reminder of your [Service] with [Business name] on [Day] at [Time], at [Address or arrival window]. To reschedule or cancel, use [link] or call [phone] at least [24/48] hours ahead.

Missed appointment message

TEMPLATE

Subject: We missed you today

Hi [First name], we had you booked for [Service] today at [Time] and missed you. We hope everything is okay. As set out in our booking policy, [your deposit has been kept / a fee of $[amount] applies / no fee applies this time]. If something unexpected came up, just reply and let us know. You can book a new time at [link].

[Your name], [Business name]

Launch announcement

TEMPLATE

Subject: You can now book with [Business name] online

Hi [First name], starting [Date] you can book with us online at [short link], any time of day. You will get a confirmation right away and a reminder before your appointment, and you can reschedule or cancel online. Prefer to call or text? That still works at [phone].

[Your name], [Business name]

Phone script for staff

TEMPLATE

“Thanks for calling [Business name]. I can book that for you now. [Book it in the booking system.] You are booked for [Service] on [Day] at [Time]. You will get a confirmation by [email/text] with our cancellation policy. We ask for [24/48] hours’ notice to cancel or reschedule. [If a deposit applies: This service needs a $[amount] deposit, which goes toward your bill.] Next time, you can also book online at [short link], whichever is easier for you.”

Three-month review worksheet

WORKSHEET

Review date: _____

Services, durations or buffers to change: _____

Questions customers keep asking: _____

Cancellations and no-shows since launch (my count): _____

Intake questions to delete: _____

Access to remove: _____

Actual monthly cost, with fees: $_____

Keep, adjust or switch? _____

Checklist

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Decided a booking system is worth it, and picked a family of tools
- [ ] Filled in the needs worksheet and circled my must-haves
- [ ] Compared two or three tools in the vendor comparison table
- [ ] Sent the vendor privacy questions and saved the answers
- [ ] Tested each finalist: booked, paid, cancelled, synced, exported
- [ ] Set a reminder before the free trial ends
- [ ] Entered business details, time zone and how my address shows
- [ ] Set up services with durations, buffers and prices
- [ ] Set hours, lead time, booking window, daily limits and holidays
- [ ] Gave staff only the access they need
- [ ] Kept intake questions to what I need, and said why I ask
- [ ] Wrote my deposit, cancellation, no-show and late-arrival policy
- [ ] Had the policy wording reviewed before charging fees
- [ ] Made sure the policy shows before booking and in the confirmation
- [ ] Rewrote confirmation, reminder and missed-appointment messages
- [ ] Added a separate, unticked consent box for marketing messages
- [ ] Asked my accountant how GST/HST applies to deposits and fees
- [ ] Set up regular export of payment records to my books
- [ ] Made three test bookings and deleted or refunded them
- [ ] Added the booking link to my website, Google Business Profile, social profiles, email signature and voicemail
- [ ] Told existing customers the launch date
- [ ] Wrote a short phone script for staff
- [ ] Kept my phone number or email visible on the booking page
- [ ] Checked the booking page on a phone and with a keyboard only
- [ ] Booked a three-month review in my calendar

Where to learn more

These official sources are good starting points. Search each site for the topic you need, and always check the current version, because rules change.

- **Office of the Privacy Commissioner of Canada** (priv.gc.ca): guidance for businesses on PIPEDA, cloud services and privacy breaches. If you are in Alberta, British Columbia or Quebec, also check your provincial privacy commissioner. If you handle health information, check your province's health privacy rules.
- **Canada's Anti-Spam Legislation:** search canada.ca for "anti-spam legislation" for the Government of Canada's information on consent and commercial electronic messages.
- **Your province's consumer protection office:** deposits, cancellation fees and consumer contracts are provincial. In Nova Scotia, start at novascotia.ca. Elsewhere, search your provincial government website for "consumer protection."
- **Competition Bureau Canada** (competition-bureau.canada.ca): false or misleading representations, which covers how you describe your services and prices.
- **Canada Revenue Agency** (canada.ca/revenue-agency): current GST/HST rates and keeping records.
- **Google Business Profile Help** (support.google.com/business): managing your profile and the booking link options available to your business.
- **Your booking tool's help centre and privacy policy:** features and plans change, so check before you rely on one.

Talk to a professional

- **A lawyer** to review your cancellation, deposit and no-show policy, and for questions about CASL or privacy.
- **An accountant or bookkeeper** about GST/HST on deposits and fees, and bringing booking and payment records into your books.
- **Your regulatory college or industry association**, if you are in a regulated profession, about records, consent and intake forms.

This guide is general information, not legal, tax or privacy advice. When a decision has legal or tax consequences for your business, get advice that fits your situation.